PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 01



DELHI ORIGIN — MOTI MAHAL LINEAGE

Butter Paneer

Paneer Makhani

Creamy Tomato-Butter Curry

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Butter Paneer

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Butter Paneer

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Vegetarian Cousin of a Delhi Legend

Butter paneer's story begins the same place as its far more famous meat cousin, butter chicken: at Moti Mahal, the restaurant opened in Delhi's Daryaganj neighborhood in the late 1940s by Kundan Lal Gujral, a chef who had fled Peshawar during Partition and rebuilt his kitchen in the newly independent India's capital. Gujral is widely credited with the tomato-butter gravy technique that defines both dishes — a way of using leftover tandoori marinade and gravy so nothing went to waste.

For vegetarian guests and the many Punjabi and Jain communities who don't eat meat, paneer became the natural substitute for chicken in that same rich, buttery tomato gravy, and butter paneer — also known as paneer makhani, from the Hindi word "makhan" for butter — quickly became a menu fixture in its own right rather than simply an afterthought substitution.

Today it's arguably the single most popular vegetarian curry on Indian restaurant menus worldwide, prized for a gravy that manages to be both tangy from tomato and lusciously rich from butter and cream, wrapped around soft cubes of fresh paneer cheese.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Vegetarian Cousin of a Delhi Legend, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Born from the same Delhi restaurant lineage as butter chicken, developed by Partition-era refugee chefs rebuilding their kitchens in a new city. The most widely ordered vegetarian curry at Indian restaurants internationally. A common choice for vegetarian and Jain guests seeking the same rich, comforting gravy as butter chicken without meat. A celebratory, special-occasion dish in many Punjabi households, rather than a strictly everyday curry.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	30m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Heavy-bottomed pan or kadai
- Blender, for the gravy base
- Fine sieve — optional, for an extra-smooth restaurant-style gravy
- Wooden spoon or spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Butter paneer keeps refrigerated for 3–4 days and tastes just as good, if not better, the next day. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, though cream-based gravies can separate slightly on thawing — stir well while reheating gently over low heat. Add the paneer fresh if freezing the gravy separately, as frozen paneer can turn slightly rubbery.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the gravy base

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ripe tomatoes, chopped	4 large	500 g	4 large
Cashews, raw	¼ cup	35 g	¼ katori
Butter	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Kashmiri red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Water	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori

To finish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Paneer, cubed	300 g	300 g	300 g
Heavy cream	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Butter, for finishing	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Kasuri methi (dried fenugreek leaves), crushed	1 tsp	1 g	1 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Kashmiri red chili powder gives the gravy its signature deep red color without excessive heat — sweet paprika mixed with a small pinch of cayenne is a good substitute if unavailable. Kasuri methi has a distinctive, slightly bitter aroma with no true substitute, but the dish is still delicious without it if you can't source it. Paneer can be found at Indian grocers or made at home from milk and lemon juice; firm tofu is a reasonable substitute for a different but still satisfying texture.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Gravy Base

01 SIMMER THE TOMATOES AND CASHEWS

In a pan, combine the chopped tomatoes, cashews, and 1 cup water. Simmer for 12–15 minutes until the tomatoes are completely soft and beginning to break down.

02 BLEND UNTIL SMOOTH

Let the mixture cool slightly, then blend to a completely smooth puree. For an extra-silky restaurant-style texture, pass the puree through a fine sieve, pressing to extract the liquid and discarding the seeds and skins.



03 BLOOM THE AROMATICS

Melt the butter in a clean pan and add the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant and the raw smell disappears, about 1 minute.

Chef tip. don't let the ginger-garlic paste brown — it should soften and turn fragrant, not color, to keep the gravy's flavor clean.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Gravy Base, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The tomato-cashew puree is ready when it's completely smooth with no visible texture — this is what gives butter paneer its signature velvety consistency.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry

04 COMBINE AND SEASON

Add the tomato-cashew puree to the pan with the bloomed aromatics. Stir in the Kashmiri chili powder, garam masala, sugar, and salt, and simmer for 10–12 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the gravy thickens and the oil begins to separate slightly at the edges.



05 ADD THE PANEER

Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes, just until warmed through — take care not to overcook, as paneer can turn firm and rubbery with extended cooking.

06 FINISH WITH CREAM AND BUTTER

Stir in the cream and the final tablespoon of butter, then crush the kasuri methi between your palms and sprinkle it in — this releases its aroma far better than adding it whole.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry, continued

Color indicator. the finished gravy should be a rich, glossy orange-red, with visible flecks of crushed kasuri methi throughout.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the curry hard after adding the cream can cause it to split or curdle. Once cream goes in, keep the heat low and simmer gently rather than at a rolling boil.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with butter naan or tandoori roti, torn and used to scoop up the rich gravy.
- A classic pairing with jeera rice (cumin rice) for a complete meal.

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small copper or steel handi with a swirl of cream and a sprig of coriander on top.

Family Style

- A shared centerpiece bowl alongside dal and a stack of naan for the table to share.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Gravy Right

- Sieving the tomato-cashew puree is the single biggest difference between home-style and restaurant-style texture.
- A pinch of sugar balances the tomatoes' acidity — don't skip it even if you don't like sweet food, as it's not meant to make the dish taste sweet.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The tomato-cashew gravy base can be made up to 3 days ahead and refrigerated separately from the paneer.
- Add cream and paneer fresh each time you reheat for the best texture, rather than storing them cooked together long-term.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Many restaurant kitchens finish the dish with a small piece of butter placed directly on top just before serving, letting it melt at the table for a dramatic, glossy presentation.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

340 kcal	12 g	14 g	27 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Paneer Makhani (Restaurant Style)	an even richer version with extra cream and butter, common at high-end restaurants.
Paneer Lababdar	a thicker, more robustly spiced dhaba cousin — see our dedicated recipe card.
Shahi Paneer	a milder, nut-forward version with less tomato tang — see our dedicated recipe card.
Vegan Butter Paneer	made with tofu and cashew cream in place of dairy paneer, butter, and cream.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why did my gravy turn out sour instead of rich?

Likely under-ripe or very acidic tomatoes without enough sugar to balance them. Taste and adjust sugar gradually until the tang softens.

Can I make this without cashews?

Yes — a little extra cream in place of the cashew puree works, though the gravy will be slightly less thick and rich.

Is butter paneer very spicy?

No — it's a mild, rich curry more defined by tang and creaminess than heat. Add extra chili powder if you prefer more spice.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary

GLOSSARY

Makhani	Hindi for "buttery," describing this style of rich tomato-butter gravy.
Kasuri Methi	dried fenugreek leaves, crushed and added at the end for a distinctive aroma.
Paneer	fresh, non-melting Indian cheese made from curdled milk.
Handi	a traditional narrow-necked pot often used for serving rich curries.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Butter Paneer

15m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

GRAVY BASE

Ripe tomatoes	500 g
Cashews	35 g
Butter	45 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Sugar	4 g
Salt	6 g
Water	240 ml

TO FINISH

Paneer	300 g
Heavy cream	45 ml
Butter	15 g
Kasuri methi	1 g

METHOD

01 **Simmer the tomatoes and cashews.** In a pan, combine the chopped tomatoes, cashews, and 1 cup water.

02 **Blend until smooth.** Let the mixture cool slightly, then blend to a completely smooth puree.

03 **Bloom the aromatics.** Melt the butter in a clean pan and add the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant and the raw smell disappears, about 1 minute.

04 **Combine and season.** Add the tomato-cashew puree to the pan with the bloomed aromatics.

05 **Add the paneer.** Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes, just until warmed through — take care not to overcook, as paneer can turn firm and rubbery with extended cooking.

06 **Finish with cream and butter.** Stir in the cream and the final tablespoon of butter, then crush the kasuri methi between your palms and sprinkle it in — this releases its aroma far better than adding it whole.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Ripe tomatoes	500 g	
☐	Butter	see recipe	
☐	Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g	
☐	Sugar	4 g	
☐	Paneer	300 g	
☐	Kasuri methi	1 g	
☐	Cashews	35 g	
☐	Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	
☐	Garam masala	1.5 g	
☐	Salt	6 g	
☐	Heavy cream	45 ml	

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